



GOVERNANCE DOCUMENT

Complaints Policy

International Society of Equity Analysts

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RELATED DOCUMENTS	Ethics Policy Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct Whistleblower Policy Disciplinary Policy Conflict of Interest Policy

This document forms part of the official governance framework of the International Society of Equity Analysts (ISEA) and should be read together with the related documents listed above.

Contents

1. Purpose	4
2. Scope and Application	4
3. Objectives.....	4
4. Guiding Principles	5
5. Types of Complaints	5
6. Submission of Complaints.....	6
7. Acknowledgement of Complaints.....	6
8. Initial Assessment	6
9. Investigation Process.....	7
10. Respondent Rights.....	7
11. Outcomes and Resolution.....	7
12. Disciplinary Matters	7
13. Appeals and Review.....	8
14. Confidentiality and Privacy	8
15. Malicious or Vexatious Complaints.....	8
16. Complaints Against Directors or Committee Members.....	8
17. Reporting and Governance	9
18. Record Keeping.....	9
19. Continuous Improvement	9
20. Effective Date	9

1. Purpose

The International Society of Equity Analysts (ISEA) is committed to maintaining the highest standards of professionalism, integrity, fairness, and accountability in all aspects of its operations.

This Complaints Policy establishes a transparent, accessible, and fair framework for receiving, assessing, investigating, resolving, and reporting complaints relating to ISEA, its members, certificants, directors, officers, committee members, volunteers, service providers, and professional activities.

ISEA recognises that an effective complaints management process is essential to maintaining trust in the Society, protecting the integrity of its professional standards, and ensuring continuous improvement.

This Policy operates consistently with the **Ethics Policy, Conflict of Interest Policy, Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct, Disciplinary Policy, Whistleblower Policy** and ISEA's governance framework.

2. Scope and Application

This Policy applies to complaints relating to:

- Governing Council members, officers, and committee members;
- Members (Student Members, Associate Members, Members and Fellows);
- Professional designation holders;
- Certification candidates and certificants;
- Volunteers and representatives acting on behalf of ISEA;
- ISEA education and certification programs;
- Professional conduct matters;
- Events, publications, communications, and services;
- Governance and administrative matters;
- Potential breaches of ISEA policies or standards.

This Policy applies to complaints received from:

- Members (Student Members, Associate Members, Members and Fellows);
- Candidates;
- Investors and market participants;
- Employers;
- Education providers;
- Partners;
- Regulators;
- Members of the public;
- Other stakeholders.

3. Objectives

The objectives of this Complaints Policy are to:

- Provide a clear and accessible complaints process;
- Ensure complaints are handled fairly, objectively, and confidentially;
- Protect the rights of complainants and respondents;
- Identify and address professional misconduct;
- Promote continuous improvement within ISEA;
- Maintain confidence in ISEA's professional standards.

4. Guiding Principles

ISEA shall manage complaints in accordance with the following principles:

4.1 Fairness

All complaints shall be considered objectively, and respondents shall have a reasonable opportunity to respond to allegations.

4.2 Independence

Complaints shall be reviewed by individuals free from conflicts of interest and able to exercise independent judgment.

4.3 Confidentiality

Complaint information shall be handled confidentially and disclosed only where necessary for investigation, resolution, legal compliance, or governance purposes.

4.4 Timeliness

ISEA shall seek to address complaints within a reasonable timeframe having regard to the complexity and seriousness of the matter.

4.5 Proportionality

The level of investigation and response shall be proportionate to:

- The seriousness of the complaint;
- The potential impact on ISEA;
- The potential risk to members, investors, or the public.

4.6 Non-Retaliation

ISEA prohibits retaliation against any person who makes a complaint in good faith or participates in a complaint investigation.

5. Types of Complaints

Complaints may include, but are not limited to:

5.1 Professional Conduct Complaints

Examples include:

- Breaches of ethical obligations;
- Misrepresentation of qualifications;
- Failure to maintain professional standards;
- Conflicts of interest;
- Research integrity concerns.

5.2 Certification and Education Complaints

Examples include:

- Examination administration concerns;
- Assessment disputes;
- Certification process issues;
- Education provider concerns.

5.3 Membership Complaints

Examples include:

- Membership administration issues;
- Member conduct concerns;

- Misuse of ISEA status or branding.

5.4 Governance Complaints

Examples include:

- Director or committee conduct;
- Governance process concerns;
- Conflicts of interest;
- Procedural fairness issues.

5.5 Service and Operational Complaints

Examples include:

- Event services;
- Communications;
- Website or technology platforms;
- Administrative matters.

6. Submission of Complaints

Complaints should be submitted in writing and include, where possible:

- Name and contact details of the complainant;
- Description of the concern;
- Date and circumstances of the alleged conduct;
- Identity of the person or organisation concerned;
- Supporting evidence or documentation;
- Desired outcome or resolution.

ISEA may accept anonymous complaints where appropriate, particularly where confidentiality or whistleblower concerns exist.

7. Acknowledgement of Complaints

ISEA shall acknowledge receipt of a complaint within a reasonable timeframe.

The acknowledgement shall generally include:

- Confirmation that the complaint has been received;
- Information regarding the review process;
- Expected next steps;
- Contact details for further communication.

8. Initial Assessment

Upon receipt of a complaint, ISEA shall conduct an initial assessment to determine:

- Whether the complaint falls within ISEA's jurisdiction;
- Whether additional information is required;
- Whether urgent action is necessary;
- Whether the matter should be referred to another body.

ISEA may determine that a complaint:

- Requires formal investigation;
- Can be resolved informally;
- Requires additional information;

- Falls outside ISEA's authority.

9. Investigation Process

Where a formal investigation is required, ISEA may:

- Appoint an investigator or review panel;
- Obtain information from relevant parties;
- Review documents and records;
- Interview relevant individuals;
- Seek expert advice where appropriate.

Investigations shall be conducted objectively and without predetermined conclusions.

10. Respondent Rights

A person subject to a complaint shall be:

- Notified of the substance of the complaint where appropriate;
- Given an opportunity to respond;
- Allowed to provide supporting information;
- Treated fairly throughout the process.

ISEA shall not disclose unnecessary information that may compromise confidentiality or the integrity of the investigation.

11. Outcomes and Resolution

Following assessment or investigation, ISEA may determine that:

- The complaint is unsubstantiated;
- No further action is required;
- Guidance or education is appropriate;
- Remedial action is required;
- Disciplinary action is warranted;
- The matter should be referred externally.

Possible outcomes include:

- Informal resolution;
- Written guidance;
- Formal warning;
- Requirement to undertake education or remediation;
- Suspension of membership;
- Suspension or withdrawal of certification;
- Removal from ISEA activities;
- Termination of membership;
- Referral to regulators or professional bodies.

12. Disciplinary Matters

Where a complaint may involve serious professional misconduct, the matter may be referred to the Ethics & Professional Standards Committee.

The Committee shall consider matters including:

- The seriousness of conduct;
- Evidence available;
- Previous conduct history;
- Impact on ISEA's reputation;
- Public interest considerations.

Disciplinary processes shall comply with principles of procedural fairness.

13. Appeals and Review

Where appropriate, a person affected by a complaint outcome may request a review or appeal.

An appeal request should identify:

- The grounds for appeal;
- Relevant evidence;
- Any procedural concerns.

Appeals shall be considered by an appropriate person or body independent of the original decision-maker.

The decision following appeal shall generally be final, subject to any rights available under applicable law.

14. Confidentiality and Privacy

ISEA shall handle complaint information in accordance with:

- The ISEA Privacy Policy;
- Confidentiality obligations;
- Applicable legal requirements.

Complaint records shall be securely maintained and accessed only by authorised individuals.

15. Malicious or Vexatious Complaints

ISEA recognises that complaints may occasionally be made in bad faith.

Where a complaint is determined to be knowingly false, malicious, or vexatious, ISEA may take appropriate action.

However, a complaint shall not be considered improper merely because it is unsuccessful.

16. Complaints Against Directors or Committee Members

Where a complaint concerns:

- A Governing Council member;
- The Chairperson of a committee;
- A committee member;
- A senior officer;

the matter shall be reviewed by an appropriate independent authority determined by the Governing Council.

Where necessary, conflicted individuals shall not participate in the review or decision-making process.

17. Reporting and Governance

The Ethics & Professional Standards Committee shall provide periodic reports to the Governing Council regarding:

- Number and nature of complaints;
- Investigation outcomes;
- Trends and recurring issues;
- Recommended improvements.

Reports shall protect confidentiality and avoid unnecessary disclosure of personal information.

18. Record Keeping

ISEA shall maintain appropriate records relating to:

- Complaints received;
- Investigations conducted;
- Outcomes determined;
- Actions taken;
- Lessons identified.

Records shall be retained in accordance with ISEA's legal and governance obligations.

19. Continuous Improvement

ISEA shall use complaint information to improve:

- Professional standards;
- Education programs;
- Governance processes;
- Member services;
- Operational practices.

The Ethics & Professional Standards Committee shall periodically review this Policy and recommend improvements.

20. Effective Date

This Complaints Policy takes effect on the date approved by the ISEA Governing Council.